



Opera Mini for BB

Opera Mini 6.5 is now available for BlackBerry smartphone users via BlackBerry App World. <http://digit.in/GMjPRc>

Paratek will boost BlackBerry

The RF tech will help users with faster downloads, longer battery life and less dropped calls <http://cnet.co/zaoCUn>

Amazon Kindle Fire

Limitations make it a mere web browsing and ebook device



Specifications

Platform: Customized Android 2.3; **Processor:** 1GHz Cortex A9, TI OMAP 4430 chipset, Power VR SGX540 graphics; **RAM:** 512MB; **Display:** 7-inch IPS (1024 x 600); **Storage:** 8GB internal, no expansion slot; **Battery:** 4400 mAh

Contact

Tradus.in

Web site: www.tradus.in

Email: NA

Price: ₹13,699

5.0
10

Features 5.0
Performance 4.0
Build Quality 8.0
Value for Money 6.0

The Kindle Fire is the first Kindle with a colour touchscreen. It looks quite similar to the BlackBerry PlayBook, but is slightly thicker. The bezel around the display is pretty wide, but doesn't support touch gestures like the PlayBook. Absolutely no hardware buttons on the front.

The rubberised back offers good grip except during the summers – sweat becomes prominent and the tablet then tends to slip out of your hands more than a plastic or aluminium finish tablet would.

True to Kindle tradition, the power key, micro USB port and 3.5mm headphone jack are all tightly packed on the bottom spine. On the top are the stereo speakers, while the side spines are completely clean.

The Fire has a premium feel to it, of a device a lot more expensive than its actual cost. Compare side-by-side with budget tablets currently in the market, and you'll understand the build quality difference immediately.

The tablet is powered by the same power package as the BlackBerry PlayBook – the 1GHz Cortex A9 on the TI OMAP 4430 chipset and Power VR SGX540 graphics. We had been impressed by the BlackBerry PlayBook's multi-tasking capabilities. With the same power package, we expect the Fire to do equally well. However, it doesn't feel as zippy. The primary reason is the operating system. What the Fire carries is a customised version of Android 2.3 with some things thrown out of the window and Amazon's services integrated into the package. The second reason is the lesser RAM – 512 MB as compared to 1 GB on the PlayBook.

The UI features a unique and eye-catching shelf design – the bigger middle shelf is the recent items and the one below that are the favourites. The recent items will list every app that you may have used recently, every book you may have opened or even a bookmark you may have saved on the web browser. Flicking through it reminds us of the Album Cover experience when it first arrived on iOS devices. At the top is the search bar, and just below it are the tabs – Newsstand, Books, Music, Video, Docs, Apps and Web. Selecting any one of these takes you into a separate layer of screens.

All this is helped by the fact that the 7-inch IPS display is extremely good. Vivid colours

and a nice dollop of crispness are immensely important with text and multimedia alike. The web browsing experience on this tablet is quite pleasing – neat, with not too many elements distracting you. The latest update brings full screen browsing as well.

The device comes with 8GB internal storage. However, there's no slot for memory expansion.

While the Kindle Fire seems like a very competent device, there's quite a big problem with it – the geographical location limitations. Sign in with your Amazon account, and all the ebooks that you may have purchased immediately sync. Go to the Amazon app store (Yes, Android Market has been removed from this device) and search for apps. Like one? Ready to download? Here's the problem. If you don't have a US credit card linked to the account, you won't be able to download apps. Or anything else for that matter! Not even the free apps. We tried two different credit cards, both international ones in their own right – a MasterCard and a Visa, but none worked.

Good battery life though, and while it was connected to a hotspot constantly, it lasted about nine hours on continuous usage.

Yes, it's an expensive tablet, on paper. Yes, it has a very sleek form factor. Yes, the UI looks brilliant. But, this is essentially a US-only device at the moment, and you can't even download basic things like apps without a valid credit card from a financial establishment in the US. It doesn't make sense buying this device in India.

Vishal Mathur